



AP

"EVEN IF BIG OFFICIALS OF THE NTA ARE FOUND GUILTY, THEY WILL NOT BE SPARED AND WILL GET THE HARSHEST PUNISHMENT...A LOT OF IMPROVEMENT IS REQUIRED IN THE NTA"

–DHARMENDRA PRADHAN
Union Minister of Education

are unconvinced and say they want a CBI investigation. "How do we know there aren't more cases like Godhra and Patna?" asks Rohit Advani (*name changed*), a 17-year-old from Mumbai who went through the Kota grind and appeared for NEET this year (his rank was above 150,000).

There have been other peculiarities this year. For example, the original last date of registration for NEET was March 9, but was extended till 16th. Then, for the first time, a two-day window (April 9-10) was opened for more candidates to register (around 24,000 did so). There has been no explanation for why three rounds of registration were carried out. The decision to announce the results on June 4, 10 days ahead of the original date and on the day of the election results, also raised a few eyebrows. "We'll do everything to ensure that the sanctity of the institution is maintained," says NTA chairman Prof. Pradeep Kumar Joshi, who is also heading the four-member panel constituted by the Union government to probe the irregularities. "The matter is in court and we are ready to face any inquiry." The fact that the investigation will be led by the very person who heads the NTA has also come in for flak. Members of the agency and the petitioners declined to comment, saying the matter is sub judice.

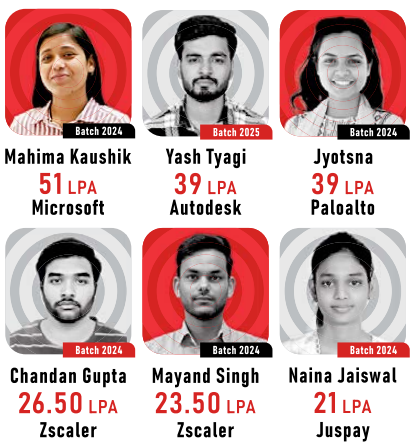
A shroud of mystery also surrounds those who set the papers for NEET. There are allegations of a connection between the exam setters and the coaching centres. "Entrance exam coaching in India is a multi-million dollar industry. The more toppers a centre produces, the higher the fees it can charge new students, so there is intense competition. With the new rules that centres cannot have students below 16, the pressure this year has been greater. There is certainly interaction between members of the NTA and us... many of its members are also heads of other universities. The opportunity and motive for manipulation is there, but whether it happened or not is difficult to prove," says a source at a top coaching academy in Delhi-NCR.

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